# *Ethical Situations of Stem cell Research*

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This paper intends to entail my ethical reflections on Stem Cell Research and the ethical situations that surround it. Beginning with an introduction to health care in America and the purpose of medical research, rhetorically involving the reader to consider their own perceptions of Stem Cell Research from the start. The situations range from: Providing medical care to all peoples (Who is going to have medical care?); The method of acquiring stem cells used in medical treatments and research; Funding supporting research; To: Why is it so important we proceed to improve our knowledge in the medical field; Is there a limit to what we will pursue?; What should we leave up to god, and when are we playing god's role; My personal feelings and position on government funded stem cell research.

Intro:

We all have medical needs throughout life: Some of us may fall breaking a bone; Catch a cold or the flu; Been born with or acquire a disease like: Aids, Asthma, Different types of arthritis and a whole list of others; We may even loose function in our organs or have organs that don't work quite right. Can we help everyone in need of medical attention with todays resources? The answer is no, but we try to do all we can. As Americans we generally go into the clinic twice a year. We get prescriptions and over the counter medicines to help fend off our seasonal colds and viruses, make special trips into the doctor when other things out of the ordinary are bothering us, where we can share them within the confidence of our family doctors who diagnose and refer us to other specialized doctors for more help if need be. Some times it is an emergency and we will go to a local hospital, this is more expensive but is a vital part of the medical care in the US. Because accidents and health problems sometimes need immediate attention and don't conform to the business hours we are used to we have hospitals that are open all day everyday.

Doctors, Nurses, Medical Students and Scientists are looking for ways to help us live stronger healthier lives and improve the lives of those who fall victim to or live with medical problems some of which are listed in the last entry and other problems we may not think of, they are even looking for cures to the diseases we now consider as incurable and/or terminal. As time progresses they are getting closer to the answers that have eluded them for years. People in the medical profession are passionate in finding a way to lower the numbers of people effected by diseases and medical problems and reminds me of a phase commonly heard from the winners in the Miss America pageant: "I wish for the end of world suffering, pain and hunger". I believe we have a long way to go before that happens, but with every new treatment, cure and person that is helped we get closer to that goal. One way researchers in the medical field are looking for these cures and possible treatments is through Stem Cell Research other ways, involve spiritual healing, healthy life styles and prevention, traditional methods and more, but Stem Cell Research appears to offer greater potential than other areas of research. SCR has been strongly impacted and controversial because of the ethical implications it occurs from pro life organizations and religious beliefs. Even with all the controversy and ethical dilemma, many hope it will one day give way to new treatments and cures.

When we hear the phrase "Stem Cell Research" many of us may immediately think about the ethical implications that surround it: Mainly In-vitro Fertilization and the use of embryos to acquire the stem cells used for the research. This is not the only method of acquiring stem cells for research. Hopefully by reading this you think of the ethical problems that surround it as not only destroying embryos, but as part of the medical field as a whole acknowledging, who gets medical treatment, how the industry of research proceeds in studies financially, what is foregone in the pursuit of new medical treatments through SCR, The industry built around the medical field, The role we play and the role we allow god to play, and the potential for disaster in funded research programs and non-funded programs.

Content:

When we begin the exploration on the ethics of Stem Cell Research we are mostly abounded with information on embryonic stem cells and how they are acquired; the major debate being: Is it right to use or kill discarded embryos for use in research. In asking ourselves this question we first have to know what an embryo is. “An embryo is the developing organism from fertilization until the end of the eight weeks of gestation, when it becomes known as a fetus” (RedOrbit.com , 01/08/2004). If one believes in life at conception then the use of these embryos would be unethical and against their beliefs. As of right now I myself do not take a position one way or the other. On the one hand you have possible treatments and cures for “Parkinson's and Alzheimer's diseases, spinal cord injury, stroke, burns, heart disease, diabetes, osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis” amongst many other uses of treatment (newsbatch.com/stemcells.ht 9/2008) and on the other hand your embryos that would be discarded anyway are used, ultimately ending the life of that embryo. It is personal opinion on whether this is ethical or not. Much good can come from it, but when is it that we are messing with the natural order of things? Of which is a question I can not answer.

Stem Cell Research has been government funded making this not only an ethical argument but a political one as well. The Beliefs and religious convictions of the people have been used in political campaigns to sway voters one way or the other. This is where I take a personal stand. I believe government in the US has too much power and provide funds for special interest causes, like swaying a vote or making international favors. I also believe that the funding of projects in the US for things like stem cell research, are taking money away from other places it may be applied with greater potential. I don't take a stand on the behalf of the embryo, but I believe the research can fend by itself with other industries out there without government aid. The funding can be used for causes like providing medical and health coverage to those who need it now and can be healed with medicine in practice today rather than spending dollars on researching cures that may only be provided to the wealthier of men and will not be available for a period of time; however long it takes the research to establish new treatments and make them public.

Overall; We are a people in a time of much innovation and discovery, how we use what we learn today will show who we are as a people. We have to ask though what is important? Advancing in knowledge and abilities or optimizing current abilities to be more available and usable throughout the nation. We are not without problems and so often forget about the guy that doesn't have much and whom will not benefit from future advancement in funded research. Yes, I, as I am sure many others would love to see great diseases of this world cured and family members who are terminal, revived and given a chance. I however believe that any one of us could be permanently disabled in a car accident today, does that mean we spend large amounts of money to make the streets and cars of the US non harmful in an accident or make ourselves resilient to broken bones, fractures and back injuries. I understand that organs and other things stem cell research will help provide are scarce right now, but honestly the research hasn't made it that far and if it is capable of doing these amazing things it will thrive and continue on its own with the help of the wide support of the great people and establishments of the world and

without sticking their hands into tax dollars.

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